

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Probe: Hundreds tied to PPP loan fraud

State investigation finds about 400 public workers improperly took millions in pandemic relief funds

By **Jeremy Gorner and A.D. Quig**
Chicago Tribune

About 400 government employees investigated by the state of Illinois improperly tapped a federal pandemic relief fund program meant to keep small businesses afloat — part of a nationwide wave

of Paycheck Protection Program fraud that siphoned tens of billions of dollars from taxpayers during the COVID-19 pandemic.

While more than 200 have lost their jobs or voluntarily resigned, some have been referred for criminal prosecution for fraudulently obtaining the taxpayer-funded forgivable business loans, accord-

ing to an Illinois Office of the Executive Inspector General report.

As of June 30, the end of fiscal year 2025, the OEIG found “reasonable cause” in 378 investigations, concluding that many state employees acquired PPP loans “based on falsified information,” the watchdog’s annual report released earlier this month said.

Without naming individuals, the report listed more than 100 employees from Illinois state government departments, includ-

ing Human Services, Juvenile Justice, Corrections and Children and Family Services, who received more than \$2.8 million in PPP loans. Many loans were in the \$20,000 range, while a few exceeded \$41,000. The investigations date back to 2022.

“Regardless of the ease of procuring these PPP funds, this was not free money for the taking,” the inspector general’s office wrote. “These loans, as with any other, required truthful informa-

tion as a basis for approval. State employees are expected, at minimum, to maintain the public’s trust and confidence. Misappropriating such funds is far from being ethical, professional, acting with integrity, or conducting oneself in a manner that reflects favorably upon the State.”

The Paycheck Protection Program was created during President Donald Trump’s first term

Turn to Fraud, Page 2

Trump meets with Zelenskyy, calls Putin

President says both want peace but sees that war could go on

By **Will Weissert, Seung Min Kim and Elise Morton**
Associated Press

PALMBEACH, Fla. — President Donald Trump on Sunday insisted Ukraine and Russia are “closer than ever before” to a peace deal as he hosted Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy at his Florida resort, but he acknowledged that negotiations could still break down and leave the war dragging on for years.

The president’s statements came after the two leaders met for a discussion that took place after what Trump described as an “excellent,” two-and-a-half-hour phone conversation with Russian President Vladimir Putin, whose invasion of Ukraine launched the full war four years ago. Trump insisted he believed Putin still wants peace, even as Russia launched another round of attacks on Ukraine while Zelenskyy flew to the United States for the latest round of negotiations.

“Russia wants to see Ukraine succeed,” Trump said during a late afternoon news conference following a meeting with Zelenskyy, whom he repeatedly praised as “brave.”

Trump and Zelenskyy both acknowledged thorny issues remain, including whether Russia can keep Ukrainian territory it controls. After their discussion, they called a wide group of European leaders, including Ursula von der Leyen, president of the European Commission, and the leaders of Finland, France, Germany, Great Britain and Poland.

Zelenskyy thanked Trump for his work.

“Ukraine is ready for peace,” he said.

Trump said he’d follow the

Turn to Ukraine, Page 5



A person watches police officers work on July 3 at the scene where four people were killed and 14 others were wounded in a shooting outside the Artis Restaurant and Lounge in Chicago’s River North neighborhood. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Chicago violence down despite major incidents

Violent crime stats continued to plummet in 2025, with murders dropping 30% from ’24

By **Sam Charles**
Chicago Tribune

When it comes to Chicago and crime, perception isn’t always reality.

At times, 2025 brought deadly chaos to Chicago’s shimmering downtown: An 18-victim mass shooting in River North, the worst the city’s seen in years. The annual Christmas tree lighting marred by two more shootings, including the murder of a teen boy. A young woman from Indiana set on fire

while riding the CTA Blue Line through the Loop.

Those crimes were red meat for those who revel in the city’s reputation as a lawless wasteland helmed by liberal politicians. But despite the headline-grabbing mayhem — which often distracts from the day-to-day violence that plays out in poorer neighborhoods across the city — in 2025 Chicago’s gun violence fell to levels not seen in a decade.

In fact, Chicago’s murder total in 2025 will be roughly half what

it was just four years ago.

As of Tuesday, the city had logged 403 murders on the year, a 30% decrease from the same period in 2024, according to Chicago police. At the same time, 1,430 more people suffered nonfatal gunshot injuries, compared with 2,169 in the same period a year earlier — a 34% reduction.

That will make 2025 the fourth consecutive year of declines in Chicago’s entrenched gun violence, though the continuing drop is cold comfort to the scores

of families still affected by shootings every year.

Predictably, perhaps wisely, no one is taking a victory lap.

“I feel like we still have work to do,” Police Department Superintendent Larry Snelling, now in his third year leading the department, said during a recent interview with the Tribune. “You can always appreciate the decline and the decrease for those who have not been harmed and (are) feel-

Turn to Violence, Page 5

Bears take on Niners after division clinch

Fresh off locking up the NFC North with the Packers’ loss on Saturday, the Bears headed to San Francisco with top seed in NFC still in play. **Chicago Sports**

Storm sweeping eastward across US

A powerful winter storm moving east from the Plains on Sunday is expected to impact much of the country with a mixture of snow, ice, rain and wind. **Nation & World**

Top shows of year on Broadway ranked

From feuding families to tragic quests, Broadway had plenty of variety to offer this past year. See our annual list of the top 10 shows of the year. **Arts & Living**



DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Fallen officer remembered

Park Forest Police Deputy Chief of Operations John DeCeault processes with other Park Forest Police officers around the gym during a celebration of life for Park Forest Detective Tim Jones on Saturday at Tinley Park High School in Tinley Park. Jones died on Dec. 3, and community members and first responders flocked to the gymnasium to celebrate his life. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

Candidate fueled by family business that faced scrutiny

Company targeted in ’22 lawsuit has been key in Lakhani’s House run

By **Olivia Olander**
Chicago Tribune

As he runs for an open Illinois House seat representing part of Chicago’s North Side, Karim Lakhani’s time as a small business owner who has worked “to help operate and grow” his family’s hotel chain plays a central role in his campaign.

The family business has also become the financial backbone of his candidacy. His parents, who serve as president and vice president of Lakhani Hospitality, have contributed more than \$300,000 to his campaign fund, propelling him to the top fundraising position in the four-candidate Democratic primary.

“My parents came here with nothing but hope,” Lakhani said in a Nov. 12 message blasted out to potential voters. “I grew up in their small business, learning what it means to work hard and persevere through tough times.”

Yet the family business that is powering Karim Lakhani’s campaign has drawn scrutiny in the past — including a jury verdict in 2022 against Lakhani Hospitality in connection with an alleged 2013 sexual assault at one of its hotels by an employee.

Karim Lakhani was not named or blamed in the lawsuit and was not working for the company at the time of the incident. According to his LinkedIn profile, he was a student at Cornell University when the assault occurred 12 years ago. By the time the case went to trial nearly a decade later, he was

Turn to Lakhani, Page 4

